



United and free

India needs unity, not uniformity; dissent must not be seen as divisive

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Independence Day speech, his thirteenth, was delivered within an entirely new political context, shaped by the recent student protests that led to the resignation of his Education Minister. The protests may have waned, but their underlying and lingering reasons for the unrest remain a matter of serious concern for the country. Mr. Modi sought to offer hope, inspiration and purpose on the one hand while, on the other, built a new phantom labelled ‘*dimagi* naxals’, who, he said, influenced policymaking and required purging. The speech was specifically addressed to the young citizens of the nation. Mr. Modi repeatedly stressed the need for big dreams, firm resolve and rapid execution, arguing that India could no longer think in incremental terms. He promised skill training for one crore youth over the next year to prepare India for the artificial intelligence era; free online coaching for competitive examinations to reduce the burden on families and improve access to opportunities; and renewed the government’s emphasis on innovation, quantum technology, space, robotics, data centres and other emerging sectors. Mr. Modi reiterated his commitment to self-reliance in defence production, including advanced technologies such as drones and next-generation defence systems. All Indians would naturally appreciate these promises and the statement of purpose.

Whether Mr. Modi wanted, or tried, to build a unified national approach towards these challenges and their management is doubtful. India’s progress is a continuum that should ideally have a compounding effect with each subsequent year. Comparing, in absolute terms, achievements before and after 2014, when he became Prime Minister, is neither statistically relevant nor politically prudent. The fact about India as it enters the 80th year as a free nation that fought off colonialism is that its challenges are unprecedented. It has a massive young population entering the workforce even as technology is disrupting life and work as never before. What India needs is an all-hands-on-the-deck approach, requiring a unified political will among parties and stakeholders that is unaffected by electoral contests. India also needs an indigenous understanding and philosophy of development rather than trying to mimic the techno-capitalism that is rattling advanced economies. This is a point that was underlined by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat in his Independence Day speech. Mr. Modi clearly sees the challenges; and he also sees, unfortunately, an enemy in every critic. As he leads the country into a new year of independence, perhaps he could consider new ideas, including those from his critics, instead of amplifying divisive ones.

Not just turbulence

India’s aviation should not have to depend on chance for safety

The August 4, 2026, incident involving Air India flight AI 2379, from Phuket to Delhi, with 137 passengers and eight crew, now has two tracks. The first concerns its reclassification: the initial ‘event of turbulence’ is now a “serious incident” after inflight technical issues and a significant deviation in aircraft altitude caused injuries to more than 20 passengers and crew, quickly drawing in the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). The subsequent probe by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau, along with France’s investigation authority, BEA, and technical representatives from Airbus, should unravel the multiple anomalies that briefly overtook the Airbus A320N – fault warnings across the hydraulic systems, elevator flight-control faults, autopilot disconnection, emergency-exit door indications and an engine anti-ice warning. Airbus’s initial data is said to support the evidence of technical errors. However, it is the second track that has received much attention: the result of the pilot-in-command’s post-flight screening for psychoactive substances.

The Tata Group-Singapore Airlines joint venture airline has been prodded into commencing the immediate and mandatory screening of its flight deck crew ‘for any substances or unprescribed medications’. But the deeply discomfiting discovery has exposed the weak link in crew screening – the greater emphasis on pre- and post-flight breathalyser checks for alcohol than on testing for psychoactive substances, which falls under the Civil Aviation Requirements (CAR) Section 5-Air Safety Series F Part V. In fact, the CAR – which applies to Air Traffic Controllers also – leans more towards random and post-flight/post-shift testing, with graded disciplinary action. With India’s air carriers expanding operations, crew citing stress-related issues, and, separately, the availability of substances for medicinal or recreational use, the regulator must ensure stringent psychoactive substance testing and operational compliance. The DGCA’s Medical Circular No. 02 of 2021, on ‘over-the-counter (OTC) drugs and self-medication’, highlights pilot cognitive/psychomotor skills impairment, drawing on the Mangaluru (2010) and Kozhikode (2020) fatal air accidents. Further, documented cases from the West reveal that even small levels of impairment can affect crew judgement, reaction time, coordination, and decision-making, the critical skills needed in the flight deck. Ensuring that fit crew are behind the controls is an aviation industry bedrock, and every Indian operator, large or growing, must uphold the highest standards. This was a lucky escape, but luck cannot be allowed to become a safety strategy.

The “One Nation, One Election (ONOE)” proposal (to enforce a uniform, synchronised timeline for national and State elections across India) represents a profound misapprehension of the structural mechanics of the parliamentary system, and poses an existential threat to the federal architecture designed by the framers of the Constitution.

To align the distinct political rhythms of dozens of individual States with the central government, in the name of national uniformity, is to prioritise administrative convenience over democratic substance. The argument for synchronisation relies heavily on a superficial calculation of financial expenditure and an overblown narrative of governance paralysis. Yet, it ignores the fundamental constitutional friction that occurs when presidential mechanics are clumsily grafted onto a parliamentary democracy.

Flexibility at democracy’s core

At the very heart of the parliamentary form of government is the principle that the executive branch derives its legitimacy directly from, and remains continuously accountable to, the legislature. Unlike a presidential system, where the executive is elected independently for a strict, unalterable calendar term, a parliamentary executive exists entirely at the pleasure of the legislative majority. A Prime Minister or a Chief Minister rules only as long as they command the confidence of the house. Consequently, the parliamentary system is inherently built around flexibility; terms are not rigidly fixed because the collapse of a governing coalition, a successful motion of no confidence, or a shifting legislative realignment must naturally trigger a democratic reset. That is why India’s elections, which ran on the same timetable from 1952 to 1967, no longer do: governments at the State and the Centre fell at different times when they lost their legislative majorities, and were elected accordingly thereafter, leading to the current situation where some State or the other is going to the elections every year.

Imposing a fixed-term electoral calendar artificially binds the legislature, completely short-circuiting this parliamentary accountability mechanism. If a government falls, forcing a fixed timeline means that the electorate is stripped of its sovereign right to choose a new government for a full five-year mandate. Instead, the system must resort to truncated midterm Assemblies elected merely to serve out the unexpired remainder of the original calendar. This introduction of variable, short-term governance undermines the stability it claims to protect, creating weak, insecure “lame-duck” administrations whose bureaucrats, police forces and political opponents will simply run down the clock rather than engage in decisive long-term policymaking.

The alternative, of resorting to President’s Rule when a State government falls, rather than



Shashi Tharoor

Fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram (Congress party), the Chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs and the Sahitya Akademi Award-winning author of 29 books, including ‘Our Living Constitution’

The ‘One Nation, One Election’ proposal will erode State autonomy, distort electoral mandates, and weaken democratic accountability

holding a fresh election, is even more undemocratic. This would inevitably force a domino effect of constitutional crises that severely erodes the value of a citizen’s vote. Under a synchronised system, the democratic leverage of the electorate is fundamentally distorted. A citizen voting in a midterm election to fill a two-year unexpired term is structurally handed less political bargaining power than a voter casting a ballot at the dawn of the five-year cycle. If full-term and midterm governments wield identical constitutional powers, it is a violation of democratic equity that their corresponding popular mandates carry unequal temporal weight. Furthermore, the logic of synchronisation dictates that if the national Parliament dissolves prematurely due to a fractured coalition in New Delhi, stable State legislative assemblies possessing absolute, robust majorities would be abruptly terminated by operation of law, simply to keep the national “one election” clock on course. To dissolve a functional, democratically elected State government because of a political realignment in New Delhi is a direct assault on the political sovereignty of that state’s electorate, subordinating regional democratic choices to national political dynamics.

National politics will overshadow States

This subordination exposes the deeply anti-federal undercurrents of the synchronisation agenda. India is fundamentally a union of States, a vast pluralistic landscape where regional identities, local economic contexts, and historical trajectories demand distinct political expressions. Federalism is not a mere administrative arrangement; it is a vital mechanism for cultural and political accommodation.

By combining State and national elections into a single mega-event, the distinct boundaries between localised issues and national narratives are blurred. In a synchronised ballot, national parties with vast financial apparatuses and dominant media presence naturally tend to overshadow regional players. Local grievances regarding regional infrastructure, provincial welfare, and cultural preservation risk being entirely subsumed by overarching national rhetoric or geopolitical theatre. Electorates are subtly coerced into prioritising national alignment over regional suitability, a phenomenon captured by the majoritarian push for uniform alignment under the guise of developmental efficiency. This dynamic pressures voters to instal identical parties at both the State and centre, penalising States that choose independent political paths and starving them of federal resources if they dissent from the national ruling party.

The financial justifications used to defend this centralisation of power are equally flawed. The claim that simultaneous elections will drastically cut public spending deliberately conflates the minimal, necessary administrative costs incurred

India is losing West Asia, but it is not too late



Raja Karthikeya

Adjunct Fellow and Lead for West Asia Studies at the Takshashila Institution

West Asia is changing rapidly and India must act before its influence fades

India is losing West Asia, one country at a time. Even as the region undergoes a once-in-a-generation shift in its security architecture and political battle lines, it is unclear what India’s strategy is ...or whether New Delhi has one at all.

It was not supposed to be this way. Just 10 years ago, India was rapidly remaking its footprint in West Asia. In 2016, Saudi Arabia awarded India’s Prime Minister its highest civilian honour. In 2021, the I2U2 agreement was signed binding India, Israel, the United States and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) together. In 2024, Iran leased Chabahar to India. All these successes though are now memories from the past.

Pakistan’s new diplomatic moment

In the last four months, the U.S.-Israel war with Iran has escalated into a catastrophic regional conflict with Iran attacking the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries, the Saudis hitting Iraqi militias, Houthis attacking Saudi ships and Israel carrying out strikes in multiple countries. Now, the Gulf countries are rethinking the efficacy of the U.S. security umbrella. They see a threat from both Iran and Israel.

Among the Gulf countries there is a schism on how to handle this threat – through engagement (as the UAE is doing) or through deterrence (as the Saudis are contemplating).

In this context, Pakistan’s role as mediator in the U.S.-Iran conflict is gaining it reputational benefits in the region. Irrespective of Pakistan’s motives, analysts in the region see that Pakistan waded into the conflict at a time when it seemed that no one could bring U.S. President Donald Trump and the Iranians to the table despite efforts by Türkiye, Qatar and Egypt.

The latest collective defence pact in Mecca between Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan comes in this context. This pact may mean less in shaping the U.S.-Iran war as none of these

countries is likely to directly take on Iran alongside the U.S. The pact is thus aimed less at Iran and more at deterring Israel. All three countries see themselves as the next target of Israel after Iran. They thus want to pool Saudi capital, Pakistan’s military strength, and Türkiye’s technological advances.

This is a challenge for India. A future war between Israel and Pakistan will inevitably draw in India given the close partnership between Israel and India. Similarly, even greater Turkish support for Pakistan in a future conflict that Pakistan might have with India cannot be ruled out

The choices before India

What then is India’s strategy? It appears to be confident of Israel’s victory in its various battles in the region given its proximity to the U.S. But U.S. politics are changing rapidly, with both ‘Make America Great Again’ Republicans and Democratic Socialists questioning the once-unquestioned U.S. support for Israel. Can Israel then emerge triumphant alone?

India has cultivated a special relationship with the UAE given the importance of remittances from Indian expat workers in the country, the investments by the Indian elite in the UAE and the UAE’s strategic investments in India. But the UAE’s mounting differences with Saudi Arabia are a cause for concern, as are its positions against UN-recognised governments in conflicts as afar as Sudan. Can the UAE emerge unscathed in all these conflicts?

India can choose to sign military alliances with Israel and the UAE. But this would hurt what is left of India’s relationship with Iran and Saudi Arabia. India can choose to do nothing as it is doing now. And its merchant mariners may keep getting killed in the Strait of Hormuz while more Indian ships may sink in the Bab-el-Mandeb.

by the State with the unregulated, private campaign expenditures of political parties. The official funds spent by the Election Commission of India to manage independent cycles are a drop in the ocean for an economy of India’s scale, a small and necessary price to pay for maintaining a responsive democracy. Conversely, the vast sums of money circulated by political parties during campaigns actually function as a form of informal economic redistribution, temporarily generating widespread employment and shifting capital back down to printers, local transport networks, artisans, and working-class citizens. To restrict this economic circulation to once every five years under the banner of austerity is an argument that privileges elite fiscal preferences over the periodic economic stimuli that campaigns provide to the informal sector.

Moreover, the complaint that the continuous cycle of elections creates a perpetual state of policy paralysis due to the Model Code of Conduct is an administrative myth. The electoral code is designed strictly to prevent the ruling executive from announcing opportunistic, brand-new financial handouts or executing politically-motivated bureaucratic transfers during the immediate run-up to a vote. It does not freeze the wheels of the State, nor does it halt the execution of ongoing public works, routine governance, or essential administrative duties. The narrative of paralysis is often deployed by executives to excuse structural inefficiencies that have nothing to do with the electoral calendar. In reality, the frequency of independent State elections serves as a critical check on executive hubris, forcing political representatives to regularly return to the doorsteps of their constituents with folded hands. This continuous accountability cycle keeps political parties responsive to shifting public sentiment, whereas a single, synchronised event leaves a five-year void where representatives are essentially insulated from the popular will.

Diminishing the voter’s voice

Ultimately, the drive toward uniform elections is an attempt to transform the organic, messy vitality of a decentralised parliamentary democracy into the rigid, totalising efficiency of an authoritarian state model. It reduces the sovereign voter to a cog in an administrative machine, strips States of their distinct political timelines, and creates dangerous vacuums where insecure, short-term governments cannot effectively rule. By treating elections as an expensive administrative burden to be minimised rather than the primary lifeblood of public accountability, the ONOE model devalues the constitutional spirit of the republic. True democratic strength does not lie in forced conformity or synchronised clocks, but in the enduring resilience of a federal compact that allows its many distinct regions to live, breathe, and vote according to their own unique conditions.

A great power in the making risks appearing humbled and hobbled in its immediate maritime neighbourhood.

Or, India can pick a third way. It can devise an active regional political strategy. Re-engage the Saudis with whom it has no explicit differences.

It can start playing a role of rebuilding trust between the Arab countries and Iran, starting with the UAE-Iran relationship. It can engage in Jordan’s security offering Jordan defensive technologies at a time when U.S. munitions are running low. It can engage in the future UN peacekeeping role in Lebanon, which is now under a cloud, with the forecast being an end to the UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL). It can even run a back-channel with Türkiye sharing its red lines about its relationship with Pakistan. If India cannot join the new Saudi-led maritime force for the Red Sea, it can work with Egypt on a parallel effort to safeguard India-bound shipping, from the Suez Canal to Bab-el-Mandeb. It can look into setting up a military presence in the Red Sea region whether in Somaliland or Socotra. Building on current military training exchanges, it can start drills and military exercises with a range of countries in the region.

Think of bridge-building

India can also appoint a new Special Envoy for West Asia – not one focused on the Israel-Palestine peace process necessarily, but one who can draw all the threads together to secure India’s interests in the region at a time of unprecedented turbulence. All of this can be part of one pro-active vision for India to support a new security architecture for West Asia – one that does not draw new battle lines but instead contributes to trust-building.

India cannot afford to be a stranger to West Asia. India has both the capacity and the responsibility to help restore peace and predictability in the region.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Political labelling

The Prime Minister often creates new terms and expressions to disparage opponents and dissenters. After previous labels such as ‘urban Naxals’, ‘*tukde-tukde* gang’ and ‘*andolanjeevis*’ became outdated, he has used the national platform to introduce a new one:

‘*dimagi* (intellectual) naxals’. This seems aimed at the student leaders behind the Gen Z protests, which have somewhat damaged his strongman image. If his warning about a ‘malicious plan to harm the country’ was genuine, he should have clearly outlined the traits of such individuals.

This vague label is another excuse for his government to target inconvenient voices and regain lost ground (Page 1, August 16).
Kamal Laddha, Bengaluru

True patriotism
The controversy over the rendition of the full version

of *Vande Mataram* at the headquarters of the Congress party (August 16) has emerged amid the government’s emphasis on its complete rendition. Patriotism should extend beyond symbolic expressions of attachment to the nation to include a tangible commitment to the

safety, dignity and well-being of its people. Mindless violence against individuals suspected of transporting beef, or attacks on Christians at peaceful prayer meetings, are equally incompatible with the values of patriotism and constitutional democracy. The democratic ideal is not

the dominance of the majority over minorities, but a constitutional framework in which every citizen can participate with equal dignity and security.
Matthew Adukani, Chennai

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